

Platform (In)Justice: Exploring Research Priorities and Practical Solutions

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ABSTRACT

This SIG calls for a global conversation around platform (in)justice. By focusing on the experiences of people residing in the Majority World (also known as Global South), we aim at creating a space for international and interdisciplinary exchange on socio-economically, politically, and culturally sensitive platform design and operation. The following topics motivate the SIG: concerns about equal access, structural discrimination, global inequities, and the desire to find solutions to those challenges. We invite the CSCW community to explore how attention to power relations, colonial residual, geopolitical tensions, and historical specificities can lead us to more sustainable and just platform designs. Through our SIG, we aspire to shape a research agenda for platform (in)justice that centers best practices and solutions to mediate some of the harms previously identified in the CSCW community. Going beyond this individual event, we will identify strategies of action that center the needs

*The first three authors are the organizers of the SIG, and their names are listed in alphabetical order of their last names.

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and assets of people residing in the Majority World when it comes to designing, upholding or challenging the frameworks enabling contemporary platforms.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → HCI theory, concepts and models; • **Social and professional topics** → Surveillance; Censorship; Hate speech; Race and ethnicity; Gender; Cultural characteristics; Geographic characteristics.

KEYWORDS

platform justice, platform injustice, critical HCI, power, cultural aspects, socio-economic aspects, design, governance, Majority World

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1 INTRODUCTION

“Platform (in)justice” encompasses a wide range of justice-related aspects in the platform world, including ethical concerns, algorithmic harms, societal oppression, and concepts of platform justice. The SIG starts with acknowledging challenges brought about by the design and operation of contemporary platforms. We recognize that

platform (in)justice extends beyond intentional design to encompass broader power dynamics that emerge from platform operations [7, 9]. Particularly people in the Majority World, which encompasses regions where the majority of the global population resides, experience disproportionate harm from platforms (e.g., through the exploitation of workers [3, 10]). At the same time, everyday users and practitioners from the Majority World are historically marginalized from discussions on platform justice. Alternative solutions, methods of appropriation, and governance models advanced in the Majority World are rarely taken into account to inspire platform development.

The SIG on Platform (In)Justice brings together aspects of research that have been discussed in the CSCW community. Previous works have shown interest in geographic spaces of marginalization such as rural areas in the United States [11]. These discussions are important to learn about structural challenges *and* opportunities in marginalized regions. Conversations around justice and solidarity, especially with concepts like intersectionality and pluriverse at the heart, can also inspire the discussion around platform (in)justice [7, 20]. Values in collaborative work environments will be crucial aspects of our discussion. Here we can build on explorations of trust and other values in platform engagement [14]. The SIG further builds on recent discussions at our own symposium on “Social Justice and Technological Future” at the University of Tübingen in Germany [19].

The SIG will focus on discussing and developing a global research agenda on platform (in)justice as well as joint solutions for the harms identified in the CSCW community. This aim can be clustered into three goals:

- raise awareness of the topic of platform (in)justice from perspectives of the Majority World
- initiate cross-field collaboration and knowledge exchange around platform (in)justice to determine pressing research questions for a global research agenda on platform (in)justice
- offer space for researchers to discuss preliminary solutions, which can then be transformed into strategies of action that minimize the harms in platform design and operation

The first goal of the SIG is to raise understanding of platform (in)justice as experienced by communities in the Majority World. To accommodate this goal in an interactive format such as the SIG, there will be a very short input at the beginning of the 75-min session. The input will build on a panel on platform (in)justice held immediately prior to the SIG at CSCW'23.

The second goal of the SIG is to initiate cross-field collaboration and knowledge exchange among scholars, practitioners, and advocates working on platforms within different disciplines. We will explore research priorities related to platforms and questions of justice and injustice among the participants. The goal is to define a global research agenda on platform (in)justice.

Third, the SIG will offer a platform for researchers and practitioners to collectively envision strategies and solutions for combating platform injustice. We stress that solutions and visions of justice emerging from the Majority World and marginalized communities should be centered. The SIG will develop preliminary solutions which can then be transformed into strategies of action to minimize the shortcomings of contemporary platform design and operation.

2 PLATFORM (IN)JUSTICE - TOPICS AND MOTIVATION

This section provides background on the challenges that have already been identified in the literature and that motivate the discussion of a global research agenda and solutions during the SIG.

2.1 Challenge: Equal Access

Although Internet access has risen considerably in the Majority World, marginalized populations continue to face challenges in participating on platforms, and are impacted by the side effects of platform design. These inequalities are exacerbated for groups with different socio-economic backgrounds and levels of education [17]. For instance, refugees rely on platforms to communicate with their families back home [2]. But affordances in these platforms can make a huge difference in access and usability for non-English speaking and low-literate groups [6]. Recent years have seen a rise in programs for the inclusion of Black and brown girls in the tech industry [16], as well as increased efforts to tap into the digital potential of the African continent [18]. However, these efforts have not led to changes in power constellations in the platform industry [1].

2.2 Challenge: Structural discrimination

Globalized systems of oppression including racism, nationalism, sexism, ableism, bigotry, and colonialism have a significant impact on the experiences of platform users [5, 16]. These systems of oppression are deeply ingrained in our society and have been reproduced and reinforced by the globalized nature of the internet [13]. As a result, political and BIPOC minorities, children, women, transgender, and non-binary persons are disproportionately affected by online discrimination, abuse, and violence [15]. For instance, children are affected by rising violence against them, including a 300 percent increase in child pornography [12].

2.3 Challenge: Global inequities

Global power relations including the power imbalances between the tech industry and the general public play a major role in shaping platform (in)justice. The tech industry is driven by profit, which can lead to a focus on maximizing profits and the exploitation of vulnerable groups that include workers in the digital and gig economy [3, 10]. Key factors contributing to structural discrimination are surveillance and the disproportionate collection of personal data by companies [4]. In addition, the mining of scarce raw materials such as lithium or cobalt (often under conditions that violate human rights) cause environmental damage in the Majority World [18].

2.4 Solutions!

Accountability for tech companies' actions and works towards more equitable and inclusive models of platform governance are important. In this regard, the Majority World has an important role to play in shaping frameworks of data governance but also offering bottom-up solutions for economic and political justice. Many countries have unique cultural, linguistic, and legal frameworks that can inform the development of alternative models of platforms and their governance [8]. Traditional and indigenous practices and

beliefs may provide valuable insights in this regard. Solutions for the challenges of platform design and operation should thus be inspired by bottom-up practices of marginalized communities and people residing in the Majority World.

3 RESEARCH QUESTIONS FOR A GLOBAL RESEARCH AGENDA

During the SIG, we will explore current priorities and future interests of the CSCW community with regard to studying justice and injustice in platform design and operation. The following research questions provide inspiration for the discussion but should not be limiting it.

- How does the global digital divide affect disadvantaged platform users' opportunities to safely and meaningfully participate in platforms?
- Which perspectives can critical diversity studies, critical race theory, and Black feminism bring to the study of power in the platform industry?
- How do globalized systems of oppression including racism, nationalism, sexism, ableism, bigotry, and colonialism affect the experiences of platform users in different geographies and cultures?
- What is the role of regulation, legislation, and governance in protecting (underage) platform users and stopping the proliferation of false information, propaganda, and hate speech?
- How do global power relations including power imbalances between the tech industry and the general public impact platform (in)justice?
- How can decolonial theory help rethink the extractive practices of the technology industry?
- What can Global North discourses around platform (in)justice learn from the Majority World?

4 PARTICIPANT ENGAGEMENT

Recognizing the importance of engaging community members at CSCW'23 to involve them in knowledge co-creation, this SIG adopts several techniques for interaction and exchange. We are mindful that a 75-minute session can go fast and will provide a clear structure to achieve the goals outlined in the introduction (also see supplementary materials).

4.1 Before the SIG

To minimize barriers for participation in the SIG, there will be no assignments prior to the conference in Minneapolis. However, the SIG builds on insights from a panel, also hosted at CSCW'23, that presents several cases of platform (in)justice from the perspectives of people residing in the Majority World and marginalized communities. It is strongly encouraged that participants of the SIG will also participate in the panel.

4.2 During the SIG

The 75-minute SIG will be held in person only. We welcome the personal exchange and adapt our techniques to this mode of interaction. In particular, we will make active use of the space provided by CSCW'23. After a brief input from one of the co-organizers of

the SIG, the group will engage in a “research speed-dating.” With two lines of chairs being assembled in a circle and facing each other, participants will confront one other person at a time and explain their current and future research interests with regard to platform (in)justice to them. Subsequently, participants will be assigned into small groups to formulate research questions that relate to their own work and what they heard from their “dates.”

In the second part of the SIG, we will explore solutions to the challenges outlined before. This will include a silent writing exercise, followed by a group discussion where each group formulates a one-liner to document their take on possible solutions.

4.3 After the SIG

In order to keep a record of the needs and solutions discussed at the event, we will create a Google document with our results. This document will be shared with participants of the SIG to add their own thoughts or review their peers' ideas. We plan to further write an academic paper that not only lays out the challenges described above in more details but develops the preliminary solutions from the SIG into strategies of action. The strategies may also be summarized in a blog post in a relevant outlet such as the SIGCHI blog.

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A SUPPLEMENTARY MATERIALS

This section will clarify the envisioned audience, logistics, schedule, and follow-up activities for the SIG.

A.1 For whom is this SIG?

The envisioned community participating in the SIG are researchers or developers engaging with platforms, especially from a critical perspective and with an interest in social and political processes. Since the SIG is placed within a computer science conference, it explicitly stresses the value-ladenness of technology and that platforms have embedded different ideas of what communication and community should look like. The societal study of such values can be key to dismantling harmful platform design - whether this design is intentional or unintentional.

A.2 Background of attendants

The researchers attending the SIG will have published their own work on values in design or different cultural and social backgrounds of platform users. They are sensitive to or interested in questions of race, gender, class, ethnicity, sexuality, ability, and education. Some of the attendants will bring a concern for social justice and a desire to address the shortcomings in contemporary platforms and other collaborative systems.

A.3 Organization

The SIG will be organized as follows: the introductory part will consist of 3-minute inputs by three organizers, framing important keywords featured in this proposal: 1) justice, 2) injustice, 3) and Majority World. The first input focuses on the multiplicity of justice concepts in various cultural contexts, also drawing on the related

panel which takes place immediately prior to the SIG. The second input on injustice will go a bit deeper into the various forms of engagement that diverse groups (particularly marginalized groups) have with platforms (particularly harms). It will recapitulate parts of the previous panel. The third input will explain the term Majority World in relation to Global South and address some of the global power relations at play in platform design.

After defining these terms and the scope of the debate, a forth organizer will ask participants to take part in a “research speed-dating.” With two lines of chairs being assembled in a circle and facing each other, participants will confront one other person at a time and explain their current and future research interests to them. Participants will be asked to specifically think about an aspect of their research that relates to questions of power, (in)equality, ethics or governance with regard to platforms. The exercise will not only stimulate reflection on research but also make sure that participants get to know each other better and talk directly to each other.

Subsequently, participants will be assigned into small working groups to formulate research questions that relate to their own work but also what they heard from their “dates.” Participants in the small groups will write on a paper prepared for them to document their results.

In the second part of the SIG, we will develop ideas for solutions to the challenges presented in section 2. The organizers will ask participants to walk around the room and inspect three large posters spread out on different tables. Each poster has one of the broader challenges placed in the middle of the sheet: equal access, structural discrimination, global inequities. Participants will silently write down their ideas for solutions on the three posters, offering preliminary answers to the challenges or asking questions that need to be resolved in order to come up with solutions. There are no limitations to participants’ expression. Participants can write, draw, respond to the writings of others by using arrows and symbols, affirming or disagreeing with each other. The silent writing exercise will take approximately 10 minutes. Subsequently, participants will again be divided into small groups to discuss what they have written down in the silent writing exercise, and come up with a one-liner in their group as a response to a challenge of their choosing - or all three challenges if that is feasible to the group. The working groups’ one-liners can contain a concrete step that participants can take, a statement of what needs to change in society, a proposal to involve specific stakeholders, and more. The discussion in small groups will take around 20 minutes. A concluding wrap up in the plenum will follow and set the stage for future research and events on the topic of platform (in)justice. The organizers will point to a Google document, specifically created for the SIG, that will document the results from the working groups and allow participants to add their thoughts or review their peers’ ideas after the SIG.

A.4 Promotion of the SIG

In order to attract a large number of participants, the organizers will advertise the SIG on different channels, including social media platforms and email lists. We will further send personal invitations to colleagues of ours who annually attend the CSCW conference.

Table 1: Sample schedule for the SIG

Time	Activity	Material
10:00	Welcome and setting the stage	possibly microphone
10:05	Input on three concepts: justice, injustice, and Majority World	possibly microphone
10:15	Research speed-dating	chair circle, chairs facing each other, timer
10:25	Discussing and prioritizing research topics in small groups	Paper, pens
10:40	Silent writing exercise coming up with preliminary solutions	three posters with keywords in the middle, pens
10:50	Discussion in small working groups, crafting of a one-liner	paper, pens
11:10	Wrap up and collection of email addresses for follow-up	possibly microphone

A.5 Primary contact

For any questions prior to this SIG or following up on the discussions at CSCW'23, please contact Laura Schelenz at laura.schelenz@uni-tuebingen.de.